Despite the Chinese government's seeking to assimilate Tibet into its body politic for several years now, it remains deeply insecure about the legitimacy of its ownership of Tibet. In the narrative-building exercise over the legitimacy of Chinese rule over Tibet, we get valuable insights into how China manipulates history to serve its political ends. For example, Tibet's relationship with the Tang dynasty is described as an 'alliance' sought by the Tibetan king Srongtsen Gampo in the seventh century. The history of Tibetan military assaults against the Tang and the imposition of peace terms on the Chinese emperor have been omitted entirely. In 2014, there was a series of propaganda events by China in Tibet to highlight the role of the Chinese princess Wencheng in cementing the Tang–Tibet alliance through her marriage to Srongtsen Gampo. More than that, the propaganda suggested – not too subtly – that it is she who brought superior culture and social mores to an uncivilized ethnic backwater.

Chinese claims that Tibet became part of China during the Mongol Yuan dynasty are being revised to convey that Tibet has always been a part of China 'since ancient times' – that is, even before the thirteenth century. When I had an audience with His Holiness the Dalai Lama in 2005 when I was Foreign Secretary, he conveyed to me that as a condition for resuming talks with the Chinese government, China wanted him to announce that he acknowledged Tibet to 'have always been a part of China'. When he asked me for my opinion, I pointed out that in conceding this formulation he would also be acknowledging that Tibet was no different from any other province of China and could not claim cultural and religious autonomy due to its historical status outside the Chinese political and cultural mainstream. His Holiness agreed, saying that as a Buddhist monk he could not lie. I learnt subsequently that some senior advisers within his establishment had been urging him to concede this point as a means of reconciliation with the Chinese.

This incident should be understood against the background of a further step in the Chinese narrative-building, which has a much more expansive conception of Chinese history. It relates not only to Tibet but also to other territorial claims of China, including those against India.